



THAILAND

Capital city: Bangkok
Area: 198,455 sq miles (514,000 sq km)
Population: 62,800,000
Official language: Thai
Major religions: Buddhist 95%, Muslim 4%, other 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Baht
Adult literacy rate: 93%
Life expectancy: 69 years
People per doctor: 3,427
Televisions: 236 per 1,000 people

These young men's orange robes and shaved heads show that they are monks.



BUDDHISM

Monks from Sri Lanka introduced Theravada Buddhism to this region in the 12th century and it soon became Thailand's main religion. Theravada Buddhism – the “Way of the Elders” – encourages its followers to obey the Law of Karma and do all they can to reduce suffering in the world. Traditionally young men are expected to become monks for a period of their lives, and many still follow this custom today.

THAILAND

THE KINGDOM OF THAILAND was established in the 13th century, and the country has remained independent for most of its history. It was the only country in mainland Southeast Asia not to be colonized by Britain or France. Modern Thailand is an economically successful nation, with rapid economic growth and a huge tourist industry. The north, west, and south are mountainous and fairly empty. About a third of the people live in the fertile and densely populated center of the country. Thailand was once covered in forest, but so much of it has been cut down for lumber that logging is now banned.

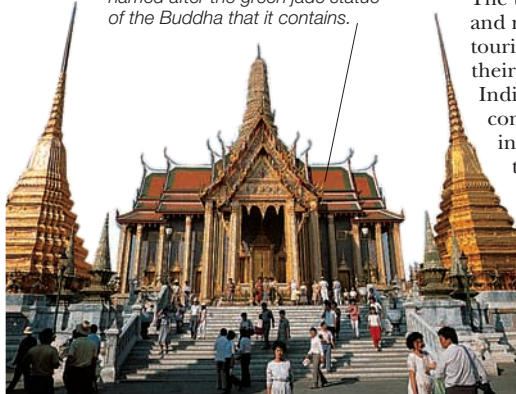
THE KING OF THAILAND King Bhumibol Adulyadej has ruled Thailand since 1946, making him the longest serving head of state in the world. The king is a powerful unifying force in the country and has often intervened in politics to restore order. He is highly respected by Thais and any criticism of him or his family is frowned upon.



A MODERN ECONOMY

Thailand is the world's biggest producer of pineapples, and also exports large quantities of rubber and rice. However, in recent years manufacturing has overtaken agriculture in economic importance. American and Japanese companies have set up factories in Thailand, which is now a leading producer of electronic goods, such as integrated circuits for computers. Many of the workers in these new factories are women.

The Emerald Temple in Bangkok is named after the green jade statue of the Buddha that it contains.



BANGKOK

Officially 6 million people live in Bangkok, but the true figure is probably closer to 10 million. Originally built on a network of canals, the city still has relatively few major roads and a limited public transportation system. As a result, Bangkok has some of the worst traffic jams in the world. In July 1992, after a monsoon storm, it took 11 hours for one jam to clear. Some commuters have converted their cars into mobile offices, even installing chemical toilets, so they can work while they are driven in.



Women are often employed in the electronics industry because they earn lower wages than men and because smaller hands can handle the tiny components best.

TOURISM

The thousands of ornate Buddhist temples and monasteries in Thailand have drawn tourists from around the world to admire their beautiful architecture. Despite the Indian Ocean tsunami in 2004, visitors still come to lie on the unspoiled beaches, trek in the hills of the north, or play on one of the new golf courses that are designed to attract businessmen from Japan.

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